



PORCELAIN WARE OF JINGDEZHEN IMPERIAL PORCELAIN FACTORY DURING EARLY QING DYNASTY

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In the eighth year of Shunzhi Reign (AD 1651), the Qing Dynasty began to follow the imperial conventions as formed in the Ming Dynasty, and ordered the craftsmen to produce the "*Huang Long Wan* (bowl decorated with yellow dragon pattern)." Lang Tingji, Governor of Jiangxi Province, was sent to Jingdezhen to supervise kiln production. At that time, numerous tasks had yet to be undertaken, and the Qing Dynasty was too busy to take care of production in the official kilns there. Thus few porcelain works were produced by the official kiln during Shunzhi Reign. Even fewer works were made with official kiln marks (inscriptions), except for some dishes and bowls with the glaze and colour of *Qinghua* (also translated as underglaze blue), yellow glaze, and egg-plant purple glaze, and with the incised pattern of cloud and dragon and *Qinghua* ladies pattern. The glaze of the dishes and bowls was smooth and bright; and the modelling, decoration and the style of the *Qinghua* inscription (frequently in the centre of the porcelain base) were of distinctive feature. From Shunzhi Reign on, porcelain making in the Imperial Porcelain Factory (the highest-ranking official kiln) experienced its prime in the subsequent reigns of Kangxi, Yongzheng and Qianlong.

KANGXI REIGN The Qing imperial court appointed officials to supervise porcelain production in Jingdezhen, beginning the practice that a kiln was named after the surname of its supervisor. The Zang kiln (*Zangyao*) wares, for example, were named after Zang Yingxuan, a celebrated official of the Ministry of Works, who was appointed to supervise the making of the porcelains with monochromic glaze in the Imperial Factory in Jingdezhen. Products in Zang kiln represented the most advanced porcelain-making level in the Imperial Factory during the early period of Kangxi Reign. Lang kiln (*Langyao*) wares referred to the porcelains produced when Jiangxi Governor Lang Tingji was appointed to the position of supervisor of Jingdezhen Imperial Factory. The well-known products of that period included the Lang kiln red (*Langyao* red) and the bean red wares, both imitating the red glazed porcelain in Xuande Reign of the Ming Dynasty, the *Qinghua* ware imitating the Xuande *Qinghua* of the Ming Dynasty, the *Qinghua* and the contrasting colours wares both imitating Chenghua Reign of the Ming Dynasty, and the bodiless vessel with white glaze imitating the Yongle Reign of the Ming Dynasty. Products in Lang kiln represented the most advanced porcelain-making level during the late period of Kangxi Reign.

New varieties of porcelains thrived at that time, with large wares imposing and unusual, and small ones exquisitely wrought. The *Qinghua* and the five-coloured porcelains were particularly widespread. With continuous innovation and the development of

technology, the *Qinghua* porcelains were made even more verdant in colour, and could be found five tones of blue. And the five-coloured porcelains had beautiful appearances with rich and striking red and green, spiced with blue, black and gold colours, all unique at that time. The porcelain producers also learned from the art style of the enamelware with copper body from the West to produce highly claimed enamel porcelains. The newly produced monochromic glaze wares included those glazed with the colours of bean-red, sky-blue, peacock green, and water green, all featuring bright and fresh colours.

The porcelain clay for ware making was refined and purely white, just like "juice of polished glutinous rice or jade". Furthermore, the delicate glaze seamlessly coated the body of porcelains.

The imperial wares made in Jingdezhen were mostly decorated with pictures and patterns sketched by imperial artists including Liu Yuan. Also recreated on the porcelains were landscapes and figurines drawn by painters Chen Laolian and Shen Zhou. They displayed double peonies, plums shadowed in moon, beautiful ladies, as well as themes from the prestigious novels including *All Men Are Brothers* (Shui Hu Zhuan), and *The Romance of the Three Kingdoms* (San Guo Yan Yi). They were usually of large modelling, with landscapes profound and vivid, and the reign mark with the regular character of "大清康熙年制 (made in Kangxi Reign, Qing Dynasty)" attributed. In the later years in this period, the mark was rarely written in the style of seal script.

YONGZHENG REIGN The imperial kiln porcelains made in this period was of high quality and in large varieties with fine porcelain clay, elegant modelling and complete glaze colour. With high virtuosity, the craftsmen made great achievements in making porcelains by both creating the new varieties and imitating the famous wares of the Ding kiln (*Dingyao*), Ru kiln (*Ruyao*), Jun kiln (*Junyao*), Guan kiln (*Guanyao*), and Ge kiln (*Geyao*) in the Song Dynasty. Some types of porcelains, which began to take shape during Kangxi Reign, now became mature. They included *Fencai*, China-ink coloured, enamel wares, as well as traditional contrasting colours and underglaze red. Also a large variety of porcelains were made by imitating the products of the famous kilns in the previous dynasties, including those during the Xuande and Chenghua reigns in the Ming Dynasty. The forms, the patterns on the wares, and the varieties should all be approved by the Emperor before they were sent to official kiln workshops. This practice was initiated in Kangxi Reign, and lasted till late Qing Dynasty. Some samples of the ware modelling and patterns (or pictures) were so established that they were followed throughout